An Impure Logic

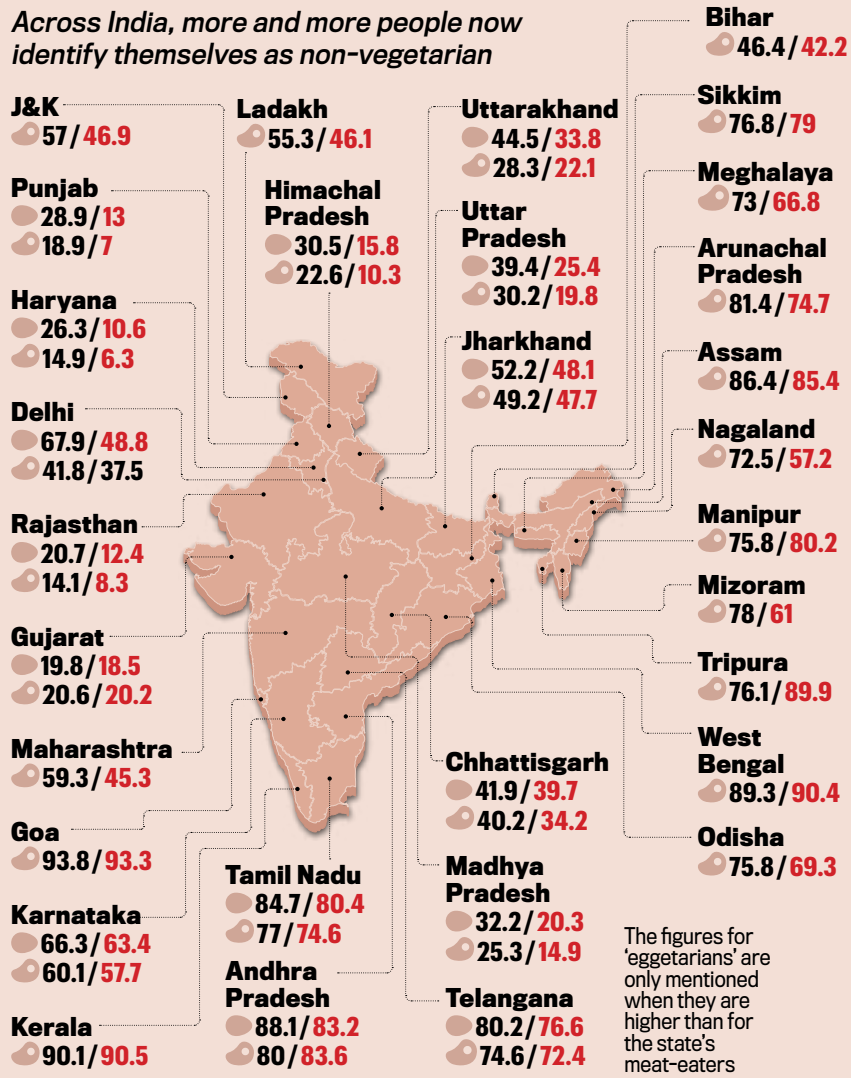
Economist and professor Dr Neeraj Hatekar says "notions of purity and pollution are related to the caste system, with those engaged in 'impure' occupations being relegated to lower positions in the social order". Empirical data reveals that India is now a predominantly non-vegetarian country (see box *A Growing Taste*). Shahu Patole, the author of *Dalit Kitchens of Marathwada*, says the community was traditionally burdened with a sense of shame and inferiority due to their food choices. "Now, the larger Bahujan community has begun to think likewise when it comes to eating non-vegetarian food," he feels.

Indeed, it's still an uphill task for the Bahujan samaj to get their case heard. A case in point, the Delhi fish market incident in upscale CR Park got a lot of press and blowback, but the nearby Indira Fish Market in Govindpuri, which caters to the lower middle class community, wasn't so lucky. The stalls were asked to close for Navratri; 10 days later, it was levelled to the ground. The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) says the market was "illegal", but the vendors say they had licences from the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI). Any which way, the market is no more.

Akshaya Mukul, author of *Gita Press and the Making of Hindu India*, notes that the Hindutva right-wing's campaign against meat is not new. It began in the first quarter of the 20th century with the rise of competitive politics between Hindus and Muslims. "During this period, there were riots in north India, and Hindus were consolidating. The binary between meat-eaters and those who had satvic food was used to distinguish themselves and display a sense of superiority," notes Mukul. He added that publications of the Gita Press spoke out against beef-eating while ignoring the corpus of literature by Hindu scholars on the subject. "From the cow, this was extended to vegetarianism. However, leaders of the Hindu Right like B.S. Moonje used to eat and encourage the consumption of non-vegetarian food," he explains. On the right-wing campaign against halal meat, Mukul says, "They are perfecting the art of putting Muslims in their place." Food historian Chinmay Damle approaches the argument from another angle. "Vegetarianism in India is often linked to purity. Groups like Brahmins and Jains form a minuscule part of the population but assert superiority on grounds of their caste and culinary choices," he explains.

A GROWING TASTE...

Across India, more and more people now identify themselves as non-vegetarian



The figures for 'eggetarians' are only mentioned when they are higher than for the state's meat-eaters

Figures in %; Eggs Fish, chicken, meat Men Women

The data is for men/women in the 15-49 age group consuming non-vegetarian food every week

Source: NFHS 2019-21

AS THE INDIRA FISH MARKET CASE IN DELHI SHOWED, IT'S STILL AN UPHILL TASK FOR THE BAHUJAN SAMAJ TO GET THEIR CASE HEARD

Halal vs Jhatka

A new front seems to have opened up in the meat wars debate, with the push for animals or fowl slaughtered using the jhatka method instead of halal. Maharashtra has even seen the launch of 'Malhar certification' for Hindu butchers supplying jhatka meat. In jhatka, the animal is decapitated using a swift blow to the neck while in halal, the windpipe and arteries are cut to ensure the animal bleeds out. BJP leader and minister Nitesh Rane, who inaugurated the Malhar certification platform, says it was aimed at creating an alternative. "There were complaints about halal meat being forced on people," he alleged.

"Jhatka is a part of Hindu culture,